and original, not re-hashes of other journalists' work. They are detailed and often colourful. More important, they enable Mehta to test the findings of the database by asking questions of both senior and rank-and-file party members. Do people on the ground "fit" with what the data appear to be saying?

'Third, Mehta is a journalist and media analyst, but he is also a scholar with a PhD and a groundbreaking book, appreciated both by academics and general readers, on the explosion of the Indian television industry in the 1990s. His scholarship has enabled him to give a historical depth to the new book—to go back to original sources to explore how individuals, parties, organisations and ideas rise and fall.

'Fourth, Mehta can write. In the manuscript, he finds his voice as a detective, an analyst and a storyteller. It is a voice that only someone with his varied experience can achieve.

'Fifth, the book raises big questions for political and social studies. To what extent, and how, do individuals shape political parties? To what extent do communications limit or empower political organisations? How unique is India's recent political experience and how much is it part of trends and processes? What is to be learned from India about political organisation and democratic government in the twenty-first century? The book's focus on the way that the political convictions of a few can be disseminated and organised using twenty-first-century technologies has international significance.

'This is an important and readable book. It is going to be around for a while.'

—Professor Robin Jeffrey, Visiting Research Professor, National University of Singapore; Emeritus Professor, Australian National University, Canberra & La Trobe University, Melbourne

'Mehta's masterful account of the evolution and rise of the BJP deftly weaves an enormous amount of material into an expansive and authoritative account of modern India. This brilliantly revealing portrait of the inner workings of the party—its ideological bedrock, organisational structure and economic outlook—is brimming with insights about India's cultural contradictions, political alliances and